Neal T. Gillespie

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Hiring Committee
Round Rock Public Library
City of Round Rock
Round Rock, TX 78664

Dear Hiring Committee,

I am applying for the Library Assistant position in Youth Services at the Round Rock Public Library. Every job I have held has been inside an educational institution or a nonprofit built to serve students: a university law school, an organization that runs educational programs and conferences for college students, and a university where part of my work was the campus library. Students have been the constant of my career, and a library is where I have been deliberately working to end up.

I should be straightforward about the one thing I cannot claim. My experience is with students aged eighteen and up rather than with children and teens, and I would be learning that part from the people here who already do it well. What I bring in the meantime is more than four years of public-facing service to students, in places built to help somebody learn something, and real enthusiasm for a role that would give me far more library experience than coursework can.

My title is Direct Mail Production Manager at Young Americans for Liberty, a nonprofit that runs donor-funded educational programs and conferences for college students. I manage the production process for our printed fundraising materials: fundraising letters, donor proposals, newsletters and conference invitations. I coordinate the outside print vendors who produce them and keep several timelines running at once against fixed drop dates. I also oversee the physical archive those pieces land in, taking samples in from the printer, sorting and labeling them, shelving them by campaign and mail code, and pulling what somebody needs.

When I inherited that archive I built the system that made it usable. I designed the SQL database behind it, set a consistent record for every piece covering mail code, campaign, date, format, audience and vendor, cataloged several campaign years against that standard, and built a digital reading room on top of the archive, so anyone in the department can search our mail and pull a past piece themselves.

I have also built two public websites. The Free Knowledge Library is a digital library of political literature drawn from across the ideological spectrum, where I designed the site, the database behind it and the classification scheme, and built the catalog that readers search. The other is statetrack.net, which I developed to publish state campaign finance records for state house and state senate candidates in all fifty states. When a patron cannot find something in a catalog, I understand why from the inside.

In a previous role at the University of Austin, part of my work involved the campus library. The university was building that library largely from donated books, I took the donations in and documented them, and I gave tours of the library. One gift I handled from the first conversation through to the books being shelved was a complete *Harvard Classics* set. I worked with that donor throughout, gave them a tour in person, and kept them updated on where the set had been placed.

During my undergraduate degree I worked as a student registrar at Chapman University’s Fowler School of Law, staffing the service window as the first person students talked to, explaining procedures that were not obvious and processing more than five hundred transcripts and exam records accurately. I have also produced displays and printed material to publicize programs, and coordinated check-in and on-site logistics for conferences serving up to a thousand students.

I have begun the ALA’s Library Support Staff Certification and begin a Library and Information Services certificate at Central Community College in the spring, with a master’s in library and information science to follow. I noticed Round Rock offers tuition assistance, which is a genuine part of the appeal. Thank you for your time, and I would welcome the chance to talk.

Sincerely,

Neal T. Gillespie